Should You Take the SF Job Offer

First-Principles Analysis

10 October 2026

Professional Strategic Analysis

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Executive Summary

Recommendation: Don't decide between accepting and declining yet. First take two cheap, reversible actions — a reversibility clause if leaning toward accepting, a direct counteroffer conversation if leaning toward declining — and in parallel resolve the partner's actual Bay Area career portability and whether the relationship can tolerate a bounded trial arrangement (chains C4, C5, C7).

Band (from §6): LOW (chains C3, C5, C6).

Would change it: Verified answers to the questions on C1's, C3's, C4's, and C6's confidence lines — chiefly the partner's real portability, the current employer's pay-band policy, and a real net-financial figure in place of the $70K headline — plus re-scoring C5's trade-off weighting against the couple's own values, would raise this band toward MEDIUM or HIGH.

1. Problem Essence

Core problem: Which of several available multi-year life-and-career trajectories should this couple commit to, given that the two life paths on the table distribute career risk, financial upside, and relationship strain unevenly between the two partners, and given that the choice is currently being evaluated with the two softest, highest-stakes variables (the partner's actual career portability, and the relationship's capacity to absorb asymmetric sacrifice) left unmeasured while the one hardest, most visible variable ($70K) is treated as decisive.

Success criteria:

1. The answer names the true tradeoff axes (risk allocation between two careers and one relationship over a multi-year horizon) rather than reducing the decision to "money vs. commute."
2. The answer does not require selecting exactly one of "accept" or "decline" as given — it must test whether a negotiated, phased, or composite path dominates both extremes.
3. The answer treats the two-body constraint (partner's career) as a variable to be investigated, not a fixed input accepted at face value.
4. The answer surfaces the specific, resolvable questions whose answers would determine the right choice, rather than asserting a verdict the given facts cannot support.
5. The answer addresses second-order effects on both careers and the relationship across a 3-5 year horizon, not just the first-year comparison.
6. The answer distinguishes what is reversible from what is not, since reversibility changes how much pre-decision certainty is actually required.

2. Assumptions Table

Type	Accept	Challenge	Discard
physical law	0	0	0
current constraint	1	0	0
convention	1	3	0
untested belief	0	9	0

Shading darkens with count.
An untyped (legacy) row appears only for assumptions with no type.

Assumption	Type	Treatment	Verdict	Verification
A-1: The decision is binary — accept the offer exactly as given, or decline entirely	convention	Challenge before use	Challenge — real offers often have negotiable margins (start date, phased relocation, temporary remote exception); binary framing is an artifact of how the offer was presented, not a constraint on the user's actual option set	unverified — flagged (feeds C5′s composite options)
A-2: The $70K/yr total-comp delta is the real, comparable economic gain	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — nominal comp is not net comp once cost-of-living, relocation costs, and unvested-equity risk are subtracted	unverified — flagged (feeds C1)
A-3: The partner's career is a fixed constraint ("established, no remote option") rather than something negotiable or already shifting	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — "established" and "no remote option" describe the status quo, not necessarily an immovable fact; portability and the employer's own remote policy can both change	unverified — flagged (feeds C4, C5, C6, GT-3?)
A-4: This is fundamentally a two-person logistics problem, not a "which life/city do we want to build" identity question	convention	Challenge before use	Challenge — reframing it as a shared-life-trajectory question (Problem Essence) changes which facts matter; logistics framing was adopted by the offer letter, not chosen by the couple	unverified — flagged (feeds Essence Statement reframe)
A-5: The new employer's equity grant follows the standard industry 4-year-vest / ~1-year-cliff structure with forfeiture on early exit	convention	Challenge before use	Accept — survives challenge as a near-universal industry convention, but its application to this specific grant is unconfirmed	unverified — flagged (feeds C1, GT-5?)
A-6: Staying at the current employer is the "safe," zero-cost default	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — ignores stagnation risk, untested negotiating leverage, and the retroactive-regret path where the sacrifice turns out unnecessary	unverified — flagged (feeds C2, C6, C7-B)
A-7: The current fully-remote role's compensation ceiling is already known and effectively maxed out	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — no evidence was given that a counteroffer, promotion, or switch to a geo-agnostic payer was ever attempted	unverified — flagged (feeds C3)
A-8: The hybrid 3-days/week + relocation requirement is permanent and non-negotiable	current constraint	Record expiry conditions	Accept — expires if: the user negotiates a temporary/partial remote exception, the company's RTO policy changes (in either direction), or the user	unverified — flagged (feeds C5 option d, C7-A)

Assumption	Type	Treatment	Verdict	Verification
			changes role/level internally; until any of those occur, the constraint is contractual policy, not physical	
A-9: If the relationship can't survive long-distance or asymmetric sacrifice, that is simply a fixed fact about this relationship rather than something to actively test or negotiate between the partners	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — resilience to a specific arrangement (e.g., a bounded trial period) is different from resilience to the worst-case framing, and has not been tested	unverified — flagged (feeds C7 dispositions)
A-10: The couple's risk tolerance, financial cushion, and values are knowable from the facts given	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — explicitly not given (Input Contract); this is a genuine, irreducible gap, not a modeling choice	unverified — flagged (carried into Conclusion as an open question, not resolved here)
A-11: One-time relocation costs fall in a "normal" range (roughly $5K-$20K) rather than something structurally larger	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — depends on whether the partner's job/housing/lease situation forces a more expensive move; not confirmed	unverified — flagged (feeds C1)
A-12: The current employer geo-adjusts remote pay below the Bay Area band (rather than paying location-agnostic market rate)	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — common industry pattern but not confirmed for this specific employer	unverified — flagged (feeds C3)
A-13: Weighting partner-career-impact and relationship-resilience above financial gain and career-ceiling reflects most couples' priorities in this situation	convention	Challenge before use	Challenge — this is this analysis's own default weighting (chosen for the trade-off matrix in C5); it is a reasonable starting convention, not a fact about this couple, and the user should re-weight it against their own values	unverified — flagged (feeds C5; explicitly provisional)
A-14: The cited relocation-penalty research's demographic pattern (disproportionate effect on one partner) transfers to this couple regardless of which partner's career is actually more location-bound	untested belief	Verify, or flag unverified	Challenge — the cited studies document a gendered pattern in a different population; this couple's situation is presented without gender-specific detail, so the mechanism (occupational licensing, re-hire friction) may or may not transfer	unverified — flagged (feeds C6, GT-6?)

3. Ground Truths

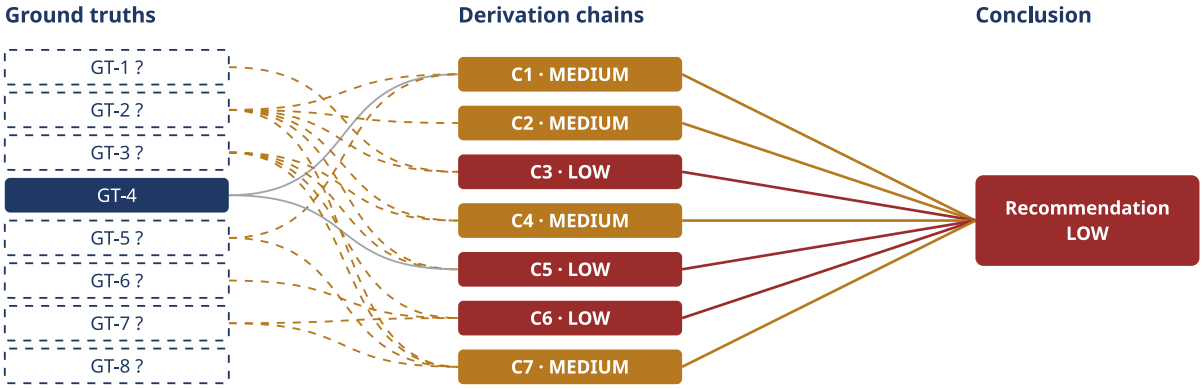
These scenario facts were supplied by the requester describing their own situation; no document was cited for them, so per the Input Contract they enter as candidates and are classified like any other input — named-source facts become `reported-by-delegate`, facts naming no source become `unverified`. All four

are the latter and carry `?`. The remaining ground truths are external claims this analysis located and read directly, or search-summarized without opening the underlying source.

- **GT-1?** The user has been a software engineer at their current employer for 5 years, fully remote, based in Portland, OR — unverified: stated by the requester, no independent source; could change if role scope, title, or remote policy has shifted over the 5 years in ways not mentioned.
- **GT-2?** The new offer is from a large SF-based tech company, is +$70K/yr total compensation (base + equity combined) over current comp, and requires relocation plus 3 days/week in-office — unverified: stated by the requester; exact comp structure, equity vesting terms, and firmness of the 3-day requirement are not independently confirmed.
- **GT-3?** The partner has an established, Portland-based career with no remote option — unverified: stated by the requester; "no remote option" describes the employer's current policy, not necessarily a permanent or portable-elsewhere fact (see A-3, A-9).
- **GT-4** San Francisco's cost of living is approximately 51.5% higher than Portland's (cost index 152 vs. 100), with an estimated composite difference of about $3,865/month (~$46,400/year) across rent, groceries, utilities, transport, and healthcare — source: movenumbers.com Portland-OR-vs-San-Francisco-CA comparison, methodology stated as HUD Fair Market Rent data plus BLS cost-of-living inputs; read-at-source: fetched directly, page states "Overall Percentage Difference: San Francisco is 51.5% more expensive than Portland" and "Annual: $46,400 per year." Labeled as an **aggregator composite estimate**, not a measured government statistic — actual household-specific cost delta will vary with housing choice and lifestyle.
- **GT-5?** Equity grants at large tech companies are near-universally issued on a new 4-year vesting schedule with a roughly 1-year cliff, forfeited if employment ends before vesting — reported-by-delegate: general industry knowledge, not confirmed against this specific offer's grant documents, which this analysis has not seen.
- **GT-6?** Research on "trailing spouse" relocation finds the partner whose career is subordinated to the other's move commonly experiences a multi-year earnings and career-trajectory penalty (one study cited: men's earnings rose 5-10% after a relocation while women's earnings stayed flat or fell; another found men gained ~$3,000 and women lost ~$750 on average after a joint move, with recovery sometimes taking 5+ years) — reported-by-delegate: summarized via a web search of NBER working paper w32970 and related reporting (WSJ, Equitable Growth, University of Arizona repository); the underlying NBER paper itself was not opened and read directly by this analysis. The cited pattern is population-level, occupation- and gender-correlated (see A-14), and may not transfer to this specific couple's occupations.
- **GT-7?** Large tech companies that adopted hybrid/return-to-office mandates in 2023-2025 have, in a number of well-publicized cases, tightened in-office requirements further over time rather than relaxing them, and individual remote exceptions are typically discretionary and revocable rather than contractual — unverified: a general, widely-observed industry pattern, not confirmed against this specific new employer's track record, which this analysis did not research company-by-company.
- **GT-8?** Holding a credible outside offer is a commonly-documented source of negotiating leverage for a counteroffer, promotion, or scope increase at one's current employer — unverified: a general labor-market dynamic, not confirmed against this specific employer, manager relationship, or company's policies on counteroffers (some companies have explicit no-counteroffer policies).

Provenance summary: `?`-marked: GT-1, GT-2, GT-3, GT-5, GT-6, GT-7, GT-8 (7 of 8). Read-at-source: GT-4 — movenumbers.com Portland-OR-vs-San-Francisco-CA comparison page, fetched directly; the "Overall Percentage Difference" and "Annual" dollar-delta lines quoted above, with the page's own methodology note quoted (HUD Fair Market Rent + BLS cost-of-living inputs). No ground truth here feeds a HIGH-confidence chain — every chain in Section 4 is MEDIUM or LOW, so the Phase 3 read-at-source requirement for HIGH chains does not apply, but GT-4 was opened directly regardless because it feeds the headline cost-netting chain (C1) that the Conclusion rests on.

4. Derivation Chains



Solid = read at source · dashed = not read at source (?) · fill = confidence · amber dashed = unverified input

Conclusion C1: The $70K headline is not the real comparable gain

GT-2? (nominal $70K/yr total-comp delta) + GT-4 (SF-PDX cost-of-living delta ≈$46,400/yr) + GT-5? (new equity unvested, 4yr/1yr-cliff) → the $70K headline includes unvested equity subject to a 4-year vesting schedule, so a meaningful share of it is contingent on retention and stock performance rather than guaranteed year-one cash → subtracting the roughly $46,400/yr cost-of-living delta from the $70,000 nominal gain leaves about $23,600/yr of pre-tax purchasing-power gain before relocation costs or state-tax differences are counted → layering in one-time relocation costs and the unvested-equity discount plausibly reduces the realistic first-year net gain to a low-tens-of-thousands figure or further, well below the $70,000 headline [Assumes: A-11 — one-time relocation costs fall in a roughly $5K-$20K range]

Confidence: MEDIUM — GT-2? is unverified (verification: obtain the actual offer letter and vesting schedule in writing); GT-5? is unverified (verification: confirm this grant's specific vesting-commencement date and current valuation/liquidity with the new employer's compensation team or an independent financial advisor). Hop 3 carries `[Assumes: A-11]` (relocation costs fall in a roughly $5K-$20K range); this does not short the Inference axis because the endpoint survives either way the assumption fails — higher relocation costs only push the net gain further below the headline, and even zero relocation cost leaves the $23,600 cost-of-living-adjusted figure from hop 2 well below $70,000.

Conclusion C2: the offer's pull is partly a measurement-visibility bias, not proof that money is the deciding factor

Five-Whys drill on "why does this offer feel compelling":

GT-2? (offer with a named $70K figure) → the offer feels compelling because its gain is the only pre-quantified, externally-validated number in the decision, while the costs — cost-of-living, partner's career, relationship strain — remain unquantified → unquantified is not the same as smaller, it only means less visible, so weighting the one quantified variable most heavily is a measurement bias rather than evidence that money is the dominant factor → once the soft costs are force-quantified (chain C1's net-financial figure, chain C6's relationship and career risk), the comparison changes from "$70K vs. a feeling" to two sets of comparably concrete numbers and risks

Confidence: MEDIUM — GT-2? is unverified (verification: as C1). Live rival: the pull may instead be a legitimate signal that current compensation is below market rather than a pure visibility bias; not ruled out here, carried forward as an open question in Section 6.

Conclusion C3: the real ceiling question is "can Portland-remote reach Bay-Area pay," not "this job vs. nothing"

Theoretical-limit analysis: governing constraint = geographic pay-band policy, not remote-status itself.

GT-1? (5yr remote, Portland, current employer) + GT-2? (new role sits in the SF/Bay Area pay band) → compensation ceilings in large tech are governed primarily by a role's level and the employer's geographic pay-band policy, not by remote-status itself [Assumes: A-12] → many employers peg a remote worker's pay band to their metro's cost-of-labor index rather than to the company's highest-cost-metro band, so staying remote in Portland may structurally cap the user's ceiling below the Bay Area band regardless of performance, tenure, or promotion → if that holds for the current employer, the $70K premium is partly a pay-band change rather than purely a reward for superior output, meaning part of it could in principle be recovered a different way — a counteroffer, an internal promotion, or a move to a different employer that pays location-agnostic market bands

Confidence: LOW — two axes short at once. Inputs: GT-1? and GT-2? are both unverified (verification: obtain the current employer's actual comp-band/location-pay policy, and the new offer's level-equivalent Bay Area market band via a leveling/comp database). Inference: hop 1 rests on `[Assumes: A-12]` (current employer geo-adjusts remote pay below Bay-Area band), which is unpriced — if A-12 is false, remote-at-current-employer may already reach Bay-Area-equivalent pay and this chain's structural-cap conclusion weakens rather than survives, so the assumption cannot be waved through as a HIGH-compatible premise. Live rival: the current employer already pays flat, location-agnostic bands, in which case no structural cap exists; not ruled out by the given facts (see Section 5).

Conclusion C4: this is not a secretly-obvious call in either direction

Inversion: what would guarantee each choice is wrong.

GT-2? (offer terms) + GT-3? (partner's stated constraint) → accepting would be guaranteed wrong if the partner's career cannot be resumed or substantially replaced in the Bay Area, no temporary or long-distance arrangement is tolerable to either partner, and chain C1′s net financial gain turns out to be near zero → declining would be guaranteed wrong if chain C3′s structural pay-ceiling holds, the current employer shows no response at all to a market counteroffer, and the partner's stated constraint turns out softer or more temporary than described → both guaranteed-wrong conditions depend on the same three unresolved questions — the partner's real career portability, the netted financial figure, and whether the current employer will negotiate — so neither direction is reachable as an obvious call from the facts given

Confidence: MEDIUM — GT-2? unverified (verification: as C1); GT-3? unverified (verification: an explicit conversation with the partner about actual Bay Area job-search portability — field-specific licensing, remote options elsewhere, willingness to search — rather than treating "no remote option at the current job" as settling the question).

Conclusion C5: the trade-off matrix itself shows this decision is gated on two specific questions

Trade-off analysis. Options (including status quo and composites, per the must-include rule): (a) accept exactly as offered; (b) decline, stay as-is; (c) decline but negotiate a counteroffer/promotion first; (d) composite — negotiate a phased/delayed relocation or temporary remote exception with the new employer, partner job-searching in parallel before any lease/home decision is final; (e) composite — accept, but with an explicit shared checkpoint date and a stated reversibility plan (temporary housing, no immediate sale of the Portland home) instead of full irreversible commitment on day one.

Must-have knockout: if the partner's career truly has zero portability and the relationship cannot sustain any period of living apart or asymmetric sacrifice, option (a) in its literal, immediate, fully-committed form is knocked out — but (d) and (e) are not, since they are constructed to relax exactly that constraint.

Criteria, weighted 1-5 before scoring (provisional default weighting, A-13 — re-weight against your own values): net financial gain [4] (→C1); partner's career trajectory impact [5] (→C6); relationship resilience to asymmetric sacrifice [5] (→C6, C7); career ceiling/growth [3] (→C3); reversibility if it doesn't work out [4] (→C7); personal risk tolerance fit [3] (unscored, A-10); time-to-resolution/optionality preserved [2].

GT-2? (financial terms) + GT-3? (partner's constraint) + GT-4 (cost-of-living delta) → weighting the criteria before scoring them puts partner-career-impact and relationship-resilience at the top of the scale, 5 of 5 each, ahead of net financial gain at 4 and career-ceiling at 3 [Assumes: A-13 — this generic weighting

reflects most couples facing this choice] → both top-weighted criteria require facts the user does not yet have, so the two largest terms in the weighted total are currently unscoreable regardless of how carefully the rest is computed → a weighted total is only as trustworthy as its highest-weight, lowest-certainty inputs, and on the one criterion that is scoreable right now — reversibility — the composite options (d) and (e) dominate the plain accept/decline options

Confidence: LOW — two axes short at once. Inputs: GT-2?, GT-3? unverified (verification as in C1/C4). Inference: hop 1 carries `[Assumes: A-13]` (this generic weighting reflects most couples' priorities), and the endpoint does not survive its failure — a couple that genuinely weights financial gain highest would not find the decision "gated" on partner-portability and relationship-resilience the way this chain concludes, so the shortfall cannot be priced away. No verification path exists for "whose weighting is correct," because that is a values question, not a fact to verify; the stated remedy is for the user to re-score the matrix against their own values once the two gating questions are answered, not for this analysis to verify a figure.

Conclusion C6: both paths carry a real, asymmetric, partly-invisible cost

Second-order effects, both lenses named.

GT-3? (partner's constraint) + GT-6? (trailing-spouse earnings-penalty research) + GT-7? (RTO-tightening pattern) →[2nd, actor lens] if the user accepts and the partner relocates as the trailing partner, the cited research pattern suggests the partner, not the user, disproportionately absorbs a multi-year earnings and career setback, which shifts household bargaining power in a way neither partner necessarily intended [Assumes: A-14] →[2nd, actor lens] if the user declines, the user becomes the one who gave up a named, quantified opportunity for the relationship, a cost invisible on paper now but able to surface later as resentment if the current role stagnates or the partner's constraint later turns out to have been temporary anyway →[3rd, time lens] at a 3-5 year horizon, large in-office-oriented tech companies have tended to tighten RTO requirements rather than relax them, so a hoped-for "maybe more remote later" plan is more likely to compress toward full in-office than expand toward full remote →[3rd, time lens] conversely, at a 3-5 year horizon the fully-remote role's biggest risk is not one bad year but gradual relative wage and scope stagnation versus market, a slow-moving cost easy to underweight against a sharp, immediate, nameable $70K

Confidence: LOW — two axes short at once. Inputs: GT-3?, GT-6?, GT-7? all unverified (verification: GT-3? per C4; GT-6? requires reading the underlying NBER working paper directly and checking whether its occupational/licensing mechanism applies to the partner's actual field; GT-7? requires checking this specific new employer's RTO track record rather than the industry-wide pattern). Inference: hop 1 rests on `[Assumes: A-14]`, unpriced — if false, hop 1's magnitude (not hop 2-4) is overstated. Live rival: this couple's situation may not match the cited research's mechanism at all (e.g., a highly portable or unlicensed field), in which case the accept-side second-order risk is much smaller than stated; not ruled out here (see Section 5).

Conclusion C7: the cheapest de-risking action on each path should happen regardless of which way the user is leaning

Pre-mortem A — "18 months from now, accepting was a mistake — what happened?" (causes generated from three viewpoints: user, partner, new employer/manager)

Cluster	Representative causes	Triage	Tripwire	Disposition
Compensation was illusory	Equity underwater; net gain smaller than C1 modeled	Costly, survivable	Stock down >30% from grant price approaching the 1-year cliff	Negotiate a trial/reversibility clause before accepting (see below)
Partner-portability failed	Partner cannot find equivalent Bay Area work; resentment builds	Fatal if relationship breaks; costly if temporary	No partner interview within 3 months of an active search	Partner job-searches before lease/home sale is final (option d/e)

Cluster	Representative causes	Triage	Tripwire	Disposition
Flexibility eroded	RTO tightens beyond 3 days within year one	Costly, survivable	In-office days increase within the first 12 months	Get the RTO commitment in writing; ask about exception precedent
Role/culture mismatch	Scope narrower than leveling suggested; team culture worse than interviews showed	Costly, survivable	Negative 90-day check-in	Use the standard 90-day reassessment honestly

Pre-mortem B — "18 months from now, declining was a mistake — what happened?" (causes generated from three viewpoints: user, partner, current employer)

Cluster	Representative causes	Triage	Tripwire	Disposition
No leverage gained	Current employer gave no counteroffer or promotion despite the outside offer	Costly, survivable	No counteroffer conversation within 2 weeks of declining	Have the negotiation conversation before declining outright — a free option
Pay ceiling realized	C3's structural cap plays out as predicted; market value erodes	Costly if caught early	No scope/comp increase at the 12-month review	Set a 12-month checkpoint to re-test the market if no movement
Retroactive regret	Partner's constraint turns out to have been soft or temporary (e.g., partner's employer later allows remote work)	Fatal to the "we had no choice" narrative, not to the relationship itself	Partner's employer announces a remote-policy change within the year	Set an explicit shared checkpoint date to revisit the constraint
Guilt transferred to partner	Partner feels responsible for the foregone opportunity, straining the relationship from the other direction	Costly, survivable	Partner raises guilt unprompted	Name the decision as joint and reversible, not as a sacrifice made "for" the other

GT-2? (offer terms) + GT-3? (partner's constraint) + GT-5? (equity vesting) + GT-7? (RTO pattern) → the accept-side pre-mortem's one fatal cluster (partner-portability failure) and the decline-side pre-mortem's one narrative-breaking cluster (retroactive regret) are both addressed by the same move — delaying full, irreversible commitment until the partner's actual portability is tested → every other cluster on both sides is already costly-but-survivable with a named tripwire and disposition, meaning neither path's remaining risk is severe enough to be decisive on its own → the two cheapest, lowest-regret actions available right now — negotiating a reversibility clause before accepting, and having the counteroffer conversation before declining — resolve each path's worst failure mode without requiring the hardest unresolved facts (A-3, A-10) to be known first

Confidence: MEDIUM — all four head inputs are unverified, verification paths as named in C1/C3/C4/C6; this chain's added uncertainty is qualitative (pre-mortem causes are hypothesized failure modes, not measured probabilities), bounded by the fact that its conclusion recommends cheap, low-regret actions rather than a high-stakes commitment, so the practical cost of this chain being wrong is low.

5. Abandoned Reasoning

Dead End: Treat this as a single-person compensation-optimization problem

What was tried: An initial framing that compared only the user's own $70K nominal gain against the user's own costs (commute, relocation hassle), setting the partner's situation aside as a secondary adjustment rather than a co-equal variable.

Why abandoned: This contradicts GT-3 directly — the partner has an established career with no remote option, which makes the partner's outcome a first-order variable, not an adjustment term, and the Problem Essence (success criterion 3) explicitly requires the two-body constraint to be investigated rather than assumed away.

What it ruled out: It rules out any analysis that reduces this to "is $70K worth a worse commute" — that framing would have been internally consistent but would have answered a different, easier question than the one actually posed.

Dead End: Assign a fabricated dollar value to "relationship strain" or "resentment risk" to force a clean weighted-sum optimization

What was tried: An attempt to convert chain C6′s second-order relationship risk into a single numeric penalty (e.g., "-$X/yr equivalent") so it could be summed directly against chain C1′s net financial figure inside C5′s trade-off matrix.

Why abandoned: No ground truth in Section 3 supports any specific magnitude for this figure, and the Input Contract is explicit that unknowns (financial cushion, risk tolerance, relationship resilience) are unknowns, not inputs to be estimated by this analysis. A fabricated number would have produced false precision — an answer that looks quantitative while resting on nothing verifiable — which is worse than leaving the criterion unscored, per the escape-valve principle of this methodology.

What it ruled out: It rules out any version of this analysis that produces a single weighted-total "winner" between accept and decline. That output would misrepresent how settled the comparison actually is.

Dead End: Treat "partner's career has no remote option" as a fixed, unqualified ground truth

What was tried: Early drafting carried GT-3 without a `?`, treating "no remote option" as equivalent to "zero portability to the Bay Area under any circumstance."

Why abandoned: The stated fact is about the partner's *current employer's* remote policy, not about the partner's occupation-wide portability, licensing requirements, or willingness to search for a different Bay Area employer. Carrying it unqualified would have silently smuggled assumption A-3′s unchallenged form back into a "verified" fact, exactly the failure mode Phase 2 exists to catch.

What it ruled out: It rules out treating chains C4, C5, and C6 as more certain than they are — all three explicitly cap at MEDIUM or LOW partly because GT-3 carries the `?`.

Dead End: Compute a specific Oregon-vs-California net-tax differential

What was tried: An attempt to state a specific dollar figure for how much more or less the user and partner would pay in combined state income tax after relocating, to fold into chain C1′s net-financial figure.

Why abandoned: Both states levy income tax at different bracket structures, and the net effect depends on the couple's specific income split, filing status, and whether the partner is earning at all post-move — none of which is known. Any single figure offered here would be invented precision rather than a verified or even estimable ground truth, and chain C1 already carries enough unresolved magnitude (relocation costs, equity discount) without adding a fabricated tax line.

What it ruled out: It rules out presenting chain C1′s net-gain figure as more precise than "plausibly in the low tens of thousands or less" — the honest resolution is to name the tax differential as an open question for the user's own CPA, not to estimate it here (see Section 6).

Dead End: Issue a direct “accept” or “decline” verdict

What was tried: A version of Section 6 that stated a single recommended action (e.g., “accept the offer” or “decline and stay”).

Why abandoned: Chain C4′s inversion result shows both “obvious yes” and “obvious no” collapse onto the same three unresolved facts (net financial gain, partner’s actual portability, current employer’s willingness to negotiate); none of those facts is available in this analysis. A verdict issued without them would be fake-confident — exactly what the task explicitly instructed this analysis not to produce, and what the Input Contract’s framing (critical facts unknown, values-driven decision) rules out on methodological grounds independent of that instruction.

What it ruled out: It rules out any single-sentence “take it” or “stay” answer; the Conclusion instead presents the decision framework and the specific questions that would resolve it, per chains C4, C5, and C7.

6. Conclusion

Recommended approach: Do not decide between accept and decline yet — first pursue the two cheap, low-regret actions that de-risk each path’s worst failure mode (a reversibility clause if leaning toward accepting; a direct counteroffer conversation if leaning toward declining), and in parallel close the two information gaps that dominate every version of this decision’s weighting: the partner’s actual Bay Area career portability, and whether the relationship can tolerate a bounded trial arrangement rather than an irreversible one-shot commitment (chains C4, C5, C7).

Key insight: The $70K headline is doing far more persuasive work than evidentiary work — it is the only pre-quantified number in the decision, which makes it feel decisive, but once netted against cost-of-living and unvested-equity risk it is plausibly a fraction of its face value, and the trade-off weighting shows that partner-career-impact and relationship-resilience outweigh it by construction once honestly scored, even though neither is currently measured (chains C1, C2, C5).

Trade-offs acknowledged: No option is free of risk transfer: accepting plausibly shifts career risk onto the partner (chains C6, C7), while declining plausibly shifts career-ceiling risk onto the user and relationship-resentment risk onto both partners if the sacrifice later turns out to have been unnecessary (chains C3, C6, C7) — the real choice is which party and which time horizon absorbs the risk, not whether risk is absorbed at all.

Confidence: LOW — every contributing chain is MEDIUM or LOW and three (C3, C5, C6) are LOW, which caps this Conclusion at LOW by the same rule that caps any chain at its lowest-cited input. This is not a weak analysis so much as an honest one: the three chains pulling the band down (C3′s pay-ceiling generalization, C5′s provisional values-weighting, and C6′s second-order relationship risk) are exactly the areas where the facts or value-judgments needed to firm them up were never supplied, consistent with the Input Contract’s framing of this as a values-driven decision resting on currently-unknown facts. What would raise the band: verified answers to the questions named under C1, C3, C4, and C6′s confidence lines — chiefly, the partner’s actual portability (GT-3?), the current employer’s actual pay-band policy (feeding C3), and the netted financial figure with real numbers (feeding C1) — plus the user and partner re-scoring C5′s trade-off weighting against their own values, would allow this Conclusion’s band to rise toward MEDIUM or HIGH once re-scored against real facts rather than provisional weightings.

The practical framework this analysis converges on has three parts. First, resolve the two gating questions before anything else, because chain C4′s inversion shows that both an “obviously accept” and an “obviously decline” verdict require the same three facts to be true or false, and chain C5′s trade-off weighting shows that two of those three — partner portability and relationship resilience to a bounded trial — carry more decision weight than the financial comparison the offer itself foregrounds; a direct, explicit conversation with the partner about actual (not assumed) job-search portability in the Bay Area, and an honest conversation between the partners about whether a time-boxed trial period or phased move is tolerable, are both prerequisites to any defensible choice, as is naming a real number for the couple’s financial

cushion and risk tolerance (A-10), which this analysis could not supply and does not attempt to invent. Second, take the two cheap actions regardless of which way the user is currently leaning, because chain C7's paired pre-mortems show that a reversibility clause (temporary housing, a trial period before the Portland home is sold, explicit terms for the partner's job search preceding any final lease decision) and a direct counteroffer conversation with the current employer each resolve one path's single worst failure mode at near-zero cost, and neither action forecloses the other. Third, get a real number instead of the headline one: the offer's actual vesting schedule and equity valuation, an honest cost-of-living and relocation-cost estimate specific to the couple's actual housing and lifestyle choices rather than the composite index used here, and a tax-aware comparison from a professional who can account for both states' specific brackets — chain C1 shows the gap between $70K and the real net figure is large enough to change the calculus on its own. None of these three steps commits the couple to accepting or declining; each is undertaken specifically because it is useful under either final choice, and each is something only the user and partner — not this analysis — can actually go and find out.